Pink in the Night

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/26017969.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Octavia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Pining, Mutual Pining, Pre-Canon, Self-Doubt, Pain, Songfic, Guilt, Danger, Symbolism, Banter, Friendship, Developing Relationship, Action, Hurt/Comfort, But with actual injuries, time skip, Anxiety, Commitment, Devotion, Longing, Fear, Courage, soft moments, Soft Catra (She-Ra), Canon Compliant

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Pink in the Night

by BabelFishing

Summary

On a training mission in the field, Catra and Adora sneak out of camp to explore a mysterious glowing cave. There, a crystal of unique beauty catches their mutual eye. But their nighttime escapade soon turns treacherous as the ground beneath them begins to give way. In the blink of an eye, Catra learns what it takes to save the person she cares about most in the world - even if she's only beginning to come to terms with her feelings

Notes

I've let this one percolate for a while now, so I'm ready for it to be out there in the world. As the title indicates, this piece was inspired by the Mitski song of the same name. I'm certainly not the first person to use that song for a Catradora-inspired creation. But I hope I did it justice all the same.

Originally, this was going to be just a quick one-shot that depicted an event similar to Adora's discover of the Sword. But I kept finding room to work the scenes and make it a perilous story of its own. So, it's now two chapters, posted at the same time.

Also, this piece grew naturally out of its second-to-last scene, which itself was inspired by some fan art by ilikeyoucatradora. That art can be found here - https://tinyurl.com/yyrn99pz

Finally, you can find links to my other works and plenty of She-Ra content at makethemgold.tumblr.com

Enjoy!

Orange

“Are we there yet?”

“If any of you ask me that one more time, I will personally throw one of you off the mountain.”

Catra’s question had been met with clear contempt and anger from Force Captain Octavia. The Force Captain’s tone also betrayed how many times she had been asked that question by her squad of trainees over the course of their hike. If she hadn’t so recently been assigned to serve as one of the new Force Captains, she might have already punted the short blonde one off the closest cliff.

“I think I’m getting a blister, guys.”

The short blonde one spoke up again, but this time, the Force Captain didn’t need to issue any retort.

“Kyle, will you stop complaining? We’re practically to the site now. Did you even check the map last time we stopped?”

Lonnie’s voice rang out and echoed into the nearby valley. Kyle, who was marching behind her, heard the question loud and clear. Still, he watched his own feet trudge up the rough hewn path while replying, “yeah, I did.”

A lanky green lizard-boy marched between the pair, as well. He carried an overstuffed backpack of his own, which shifted back and forth as he watched his friends nip off a few more exchanges. Kyle looked even more disheartened after, so the lizard-boy hung back a bit to walk beside him. The lizard-boy patted his friend on the side and gave him a cheery *rawr*.

“Thanks, Rogelio,” Kyle sighed. “I’m glad at least one person is watching out for me.”

Meanwhile, at the front of the pack, a blonde young woman was practically bouncing up the mountain path. She was even out in front of Force Captain Octavia, who had effectively given up trying to keep the cadet reigned in. *She never seems to run out of energy,* the Force Captain thought, *so she can lead the group if she wants.*

Just as the Force Captain began to enjoy the first minute of silence that she'd experienced all day, the blonde out in front piped up with an observation. "Force Captain Octavia, I have a scouting report on the path up ahead."

With a heavy sigh, Octavia obliged the young cadet. "Just tell me what you can see, Cadet Adora."

"I think I've spotted our objective site," the eager cadet called back while grabbing her canteen from the side of her neatly-arranged pack.

"That's good. We should be arriving right on time, if that's the case."

Even with this modicum of praise, Adora's face beamed. Some folks would say that she lived to please her superiors, but it was also clear that their praise was well-earned. After all, this was the cadet who had found a fresh water source and hung the squad's bear bags the previous evening, all on her own. Even back in the Fright Zone, Adora's capabilities in group training sessions showed that she was a cut above the rest.

"Catra, can you see it yet? It's right up there!" Adora gestured through the tree line while calling back to her best friend, who was still a bit dreary from being woken up early to start the day's march.

"Yeah, I think so," the brunette replied while pushing some of her wild bangs out of her eyes. In truth, she wasn't even sure what this objective point looked like. She hadn't really reviewed the

map that morning because she correctly assumed that Adora would lead the way, regardless.

After just a few more minutes of walking uphill, Catra did manage to spot a clearing that she suspected was the objective point. The area didn't feature any tree cover to speak of, but it was raised above its surroundings. So, it was clearly a strategically sound place to make camp. The views over the rest of the area were pretty remarkable, too, with aspen trees dotting the landscape. But like with most things, Catra didn't voice her thoughts on that matter.

"It looks like Cadet Adora was correct," Octavia called back to the squad's stragglers. "We have arrived at our destination for the day. Before anyone sits down for a break, I want someone to volunteer to scout out the area for threats."

No sooner had Adora dropped her heavy pack then she had raised her hand emphatically to volunteer. "I'll go! I want to see the rest of the area."

After looking around and seeing no other volunteers, the Force Captain accepted the offer. "Alright, Cadet Adora. You have ten minutes to scout out the area. Get going."

Before turning and heading back into the underbrush, Adora spoke up again. "Can Cadet Catra come with me? I could probably cover more ground with her."

"I don't see why not," the Force Captain replied. "But keep on task out there. I still expect you back in 10 minutes."

With a swift salute, Adora gave a regulation, "Yes, ma'am!" Catra simply nodded and dropped her own pack beside a large stump.

As the pair stepped over a fallen log and entered into the underbrush proper, Adora remained mostly quiet as she focused on the task at hand. Catra didn't care one way or another if the area was scouted properly. So, she asked aloud, "why did you

volunteer me for this? You know I don't like pointless busy work like this."

Adora pulled a branch out of their path and gestured for Catra's to climb through. As she passed through and dropped the branch behind herself, she smiled and replied, "I thought it would be more fun to have you come along. Plus, I didn't get to talk to you for the entire hike up here."

"And whose fault is that, Miss 'I Want to Be First Up the Mountain'?" Catra teased.

Adora laughed off the mockery, but still wanted to defend herself. "Sorry! It's just…we never get any training missions away from the Fright Zone anymore. Don't get me wrong – the Fright Zone is fine, but a change of scenery is nice, too. It's really too bad the closest forest to the Fright Zone is controlled by the Princesses."

"Yeah, I don't really think an overnight trip to the Whispering Woods would be the kind of adventure you're looking for." As Catra said this, she hopped up and swatted at a low-hanging vine.

Without warning, Adora extended her collapsible quarterstaff and turned to face Catra with a bold look on her face. "Maybe I am up for that kind of adventure? I mean, I bet I could take on a whole squad of rebel soldiers."

Catra simply continued to walk by, feigning as if she hadn't seen the show of machismo. "As if. This is the same girl who hit herself during laser rifle training last week, right?"

"That was an accident! And besides, I still made it to the last round."

"You made it all the way to the last round, just to be eliminated by yours truly."

For a moment, Adora thought she spotted something up ahead. But upon closer inspection, she saw that it was just a woodland

critter. Looking back to her friend, she admitted, “Okay, your last shot was pretty impressive. I never knew you had such good aim!”

Adora’s compliment caused the young brunette to blush lightly. Adora didn’t notice, though, as she was a few steps ahead at this point. Instead, Catra simply scratched her neck sheepishly and replied, “It was a lucky shot, if anything.”

“Lucky or not,” Adora pointed out, “you hit me from all the way across the arena without using your sights. I don’t even think Lonnie could have pulled that off.”

“Maybe we’ll have to have a rematch when we get back, then,” Catra suggested. “Octavia’s been on my back to train more anyway.”

Adora turned her head and pointed a single finger-gun in Catra’s direction. “Sounds like a date.”

Her word choice didn’t help Catra’s blush at all, but she quickly shook the warmth in her cheeks away. That kept happening without warning and she didn’t know why. That wasn’t entirely true – she had an inkling, but she wasn’t about to admit that to herself or anyone else. So, as soon as she saw a distraction in view, she called it out.

“Hey, what’s that up there?”

Adora turned her gaze to follow Catra’s pointed finger and saw a faint glow further up the hill. It could have been a campfire from a distance…except that it was still midday, making it unlikely that that much light could be visible from a lit fire. It could have been a spotlight, as well, but that was fairly unlikely this high up a mountain.

“I see it…” Adora replied in a whisper, as if she were worried that they might be overheard, “what do you think it is?”

Catra studied the glowing spot further. “I don’t know. But it looks oddly…natural.”

“You’re right. Could it be some weird animal? Like the kind in the Whispering Woods?”

Catra’s curiosity had been piqued now, even though she had originally meant for this to be a distraction. “It could be. Let’s go check it out.” With that, Catra started to climb the hill again while giving a wide birth to the glowing light’s source.

“Hey, wait up!” Adora started off at a brisk pace as well while still trying to move as quietly possible.

As the pair grew closer, they both noticed that the light source wasn’t moving or shifting. In fact, as Catra observed, it wasn’t even flickering or wavering. With that in mind, she felt emboldened to move in even closer. She signaled her intent to Adora, who followed close behind.

Soon, the pair found themselves entering into a small clearing. There, they found no evidence of inhabitance, temporary or otherwise. Indeed, there weren’t any living creatures to be seen in the area. Instead, they saw a cave-like opening at the end of the clearing, from which a soft, orange light poured forth.

“That must be where the light is coming from,” Adora guessed.

“Yeah,” Catra agreed, “but what is it?” After pausing to examine the mysterious luminescence further, she declared, “ I want a closer look.” And so, she continued her careful approach, with Adora carrying up the rear.

A minute later and the pair reached the cave’s entrance. From where they stood, neither could tell how deep it continued on. But it was clear that this wasn’t a normal grotto, based upon its interior walls. There, both girls observed several imbedded veins of luminescent crystal that wound their way further inward, all the way until they were out of sight.

Adora’s hesitance had begun to show through now, first in her body language and then in her words. “We probably shouldn’t go in there. We don’t know who or what’s in there.”

“Probably not,” Catra admitted, “but I still want to.”

Glancing up at the daytime moons above, Adora put forth another excuse. “We probably only have a couple minutes to finish up this sweep, anyway. We should get back before Octavia notices how long we’ve been gone.”

Catra replied with a frown that silently said, “you can’t be serious.” Her actual words weren’t much more acquiescent, either. “Come on! It would only take a couple minutes. Octavia’s probably distracted by Kyle’s latest mistake by now, anyway.”

Adora gave the cave one more serious look. There was something almost magical about it that she couldn’t ignore. But that feeling also spurred a sense of inhibition in the young woman, who had been trained all of her life to detest the planet’s magical forces. She wasn’t afraid of this cave by any means…but she also had a creeping feeling like she’d be in danger if she investigated it any further. That would mean putting Catra in danger, too, and though she only recognized that fear subconsciously, that prospect felt even worse.

“No, we should get back to camp,” Adora insisted. She hesitated for moment further before also admitting, “I just have a bad feeling about this place.”

With an intentionally large sigh, Catra threw up her arms in fake defeat. “Alright, alright. Let’s go back to our boring camp so we can get yelled at by Octavia all evening. Oh wait, that’s just me.” Her follow-up glare was meant to accent her sarcasm, but that was lost on her friend.

“That’s not true,” Adora claimed while trying to defend herself. “Octavia doesn’t like either of us, remember? I don’t think she’s ever forgotten that you called her a ‘dumb head’.

But just as she said that, Adora spotted something else deep within the cave. Therein, at the point where the orange crystal veins all vanished into darkness, there was another light. But this

one had a crisp pink hue that made it stand out. It appeared to shine forth all of a sudden, as if it were a lighthouse beacon signaling to Adora. Even in that split second, Adora could feel her eyes lock onto it like it was an enemy combatant.

Almost immediately though, Adora's concentration was broken by Catra's teasing voice. "Did you even hear me?"

"Oh, um…yes?"

"You obviously didn't. I was saying that Octavia would be someone to hold a grudge against children."

Adora turned to look for the source of pink light again, but it was gone. Thinking that she'd just seen the orange crystals reflecting in the daylight, she returned her focus to her friend, who was now a number of paces ahead of her. "I mean, you did scratch out one of her eyes."

With her hands thrown up in a fake admission of guilt, Catra sarcastically shouted, "You scratch out one commanding officer's eye and suddenly you're the Horde's greatest enemy! How is that even fair?"

After jogging to catch up, Adora threw a hand onto Catra's shoulder for reassurance. "Like it matters, anyway. Eventually, we'll both be way better Force Captains than Octavia ever was."

Though her outburst had been in jest, Catra still took comfort in her best friend's genuine response.

"Is that a promise?"

A few minutes later, Catra and Adora scampered back into their squad's assembly site. Though they had only been gone for around 20 minutes, the site was beginning to take shape, with three small tents assembled against the far tree line. Adora even noticed that Kyle had gathered up everyone's pack and assembled them in an orderly line.

Octavia spotted the pair as soon as they poked out of the underbrush and called them over. She looked a bit agitated, though this may have had something to do with the leaky canteen she held in her hand.

"Cadet Adora, report in. Did you spot anything of interest on your scouting sweep?"

Immediately, Adora stood at attention and saluted. She then lowered her hand and described their brief excursion. "Force Captain Octavia, my scouting sweep was uneventful. I did not spot any immediate threats or obstacles that would pose a risk to the squad."

Octavia nodded approvingly. "That's good to hear."

Adora maintained her serious stance and continued. "However, we did spot an unusual cave about a quarter mile uphill from this location. It contained an unusual orange crystal structure that did not appear dangerous in nature. We only observed it from a distance, however, and from that distance, we did not perceive any inhabitant in or around the cave."

"That is unusual, yes," the Force Captain agreed, "duly noted." After placing the leaking canteen down, Octavia continued, "Thank you for your report, Cadet Adora. Your initiative in carrying out that sweep is appreciated. That kind of initiative may be a real asset to you as a Force Captain one day."

With a stiff nod, Adora accepted her commanding officer's praise. "Yes, ma'am."

For a moment, Octavia looked as if she were going to walk away and return to her own work. But she caught herself as she took her first step and straightened back up. "Oh, right. Cadet Catra, report in on your observations."

Catra stood at a loose attention and saluted silently. "I didn't spot anything else besides what Cadet Adora described."

"I expected as much," Octavia sniggered.

Adora wasn't usually one to speak out of line. But even so, she found herself suddenly blurting out, "Actually, Force Captain, Catra's the one who spotted the cave. I had overlooked it."

Octavia's sigh indicated that she wasn't looking to praise Catra for that observation. Instead, she just glared back at Catra and said, "I'm glad to hear that you managed to contribute on scouting duty. But you still took twice as long as I asked to complete the sweep. If it happens again, I'll have you both on cleaning duty when we get back to the Fright Zone."

There was some restrained anger in Catra's eyes now, but she managed to not show it in the rest of her face. Instead, she stared straight ahead and replied, "Yes, ma'am."

The Force Captain glanced around the area and noticed the other cadets working to assemble the site's structures. After running through her mental checklist, she looked back down at her cadets and commanded, "Alright, your next duty will be to establish the perimeter. There should be some laser stakes in Rogelio's pack – use those."

In unison, both young women saluted and replied, "Yes, ma'am." They both maintained their attention stance until Octavia grabbed her leaky canteen again and walked back toward her own tent.

After lowering their salute, the pair started to make their way over to the pack line. Once there, Adora pulled out Rogelio's pack (which was marked with a small, green, lizard-shaped tag) and began to search for the stake case.

As she continued to search, she heard Catra let out a weighted, "Hmmmmm?" More often than not, Adora knew that this was her friend's subtle way of saying, "Can you believe that?" But she didn't understand what the brunette was presently concerned about.

"What's up? Did you see the stakes in here? Rogelio really could have packed this better…"

Catra's exasperated expression indicated otherwise. "No, Adora. This is what I was telling you about last night. Anytime we do something together, everyone is eager to lump praise on you for literally breathing. Meanwhile, they just toss crackers at me as an afterthought. Shadow Weaver, Grizzlor, Cobalt – all of them look at me like I'm chopped liver." A genuine pout then appeared on Catra's face, which was a rarity given her propensity for sarcasm.

As she continued to dig through the haphazard pack, Adora was quick to supply some encouragement. "Don't let Octavia get to you. Like you said before, it wouldn't be beyond her to still hold a grudge."

"Besides," she added, "since when have you ever sought praise from our officers?"

Catra turned away and scratched at her neck sheepishly. "I don't need their praise…but I wouldn't mind being recognized for my contributions every now and then."

After a bit more rustling around within the pack, Adora stood up from her crouch with the stake case in hand. As she passed over the container, she gave Catra an earnest smile and said, "Well, *I'm* glad that you came with me to scout the area. Even busy work like that is better with you there."

With that, Adora started to pace off toward the site's edge with a stake already in hand. Catra followed slowly at first as she thought about the compliment she'd been paid. Adora was right – she wasn't one to seek approval from any of their superiors. She

wouldn’t say that she sought Adora’s attention either, but…it still felt nice all the same.

That thought brought a small smile to Catra’s glower as she jogged to catch up. Her mood was alright brightening up and in the recesses of her mind, she could sense why. But she wouldn’t say why just yet, or maybe not for a long while. Either way, now wasn’t the right time. As far as Catra was concerned, those feelings could wait. They had all the time in the world together, right?

Instead, she chose to distract herself with something she already excelled at.

“I bet I can put down more of these stakes down before you,” she challenged

Adora looked back with a competitive spark in her eyes.

“You’re on.”

Hours later, the day’s last light faded from the sky as the daytime moons set beneath the tree line. By now, the Horde trainee encampment was fully established, with a row of tents and canopies surrounding a central fire pit. There, at the fire pit, five cadets sat on logs they’d dragged from the forest, enjoying their evening meal.

As was often the case with this squad, they ate fairly quietly in terms of chatter. Their dinner manners weren’t fit for formal company, perhaps, but the Horde cared little for such formalities. At this point, Adora and company were just happy to have a meal that was neither grey nor square-shaped.

There were a few peeps around the fire after a while, though, especially after Octavia walked back to her tent and out of earshot.

Lonnie was the first to speak up, in a hushed tone. "I swear, if this was the only thing the mess hall served for dinner, I'd happily eat it every day."

"Agreed." Adora managed to voice her opinions concisely between spoonfuls of the hearty mixture. The blonde was actually on her second bowl of a concoction known only as "woodland stew" on its recipe card. Theoretically, it was supposed to be worse than normal Horde rations because it required scavenging for all of its ingredients. But it was an agreed upon truth among Horde cadets that this stew was far and away better than any colorless bar served back in the Fright Zone.

The problem was, though, that Horde officers were supposed to enforce the idea that this stew was hard to make and thus, a kind of punishment meant to build cadets' characters. That's why, when Octavia returned, Catra began to fake a cough after taking a bite.

"Why do we have to eat this stuff?" she sarcastically complained once she knew that the Force Captain was back in earshot. As she said it, she gave Adora a knowing look that keyed her into the farce.

Adora then set her bowl aside quickly, perhaps to hide that she'd had seconds already. "I know, right? It's hardly worth it after all that time it took to make it." Adora's sarcasm paled in comparison to Catra's, likely because she was a far worse liar.

Kyle began to pipe up to add in his genuine thoughts on the dish. But before he could ruin the ruse, the Force Captain spoke up with a fresh command. "That's enough from all of you. Eat what you've got and be happy about it."

As she set down a knapsack on one of the seating logs, Octavia continued. “Anyway, I’m getting ready to head out. Hordak himself asked me to run a scouting mission on a village in the nearby valley. I’ll be gone for a few hours, so you’d all better stay put until I’m back.”

“In fact,” the officer pondered while looking up at the rising night moons, “how about you all get in some sparing practice tonight?”

There was a uniform groan among the group, but the Force Captain was quick to curtail their displeasure. “Oh, so it’s like that? Then I’ll repeat myself. You will practice sparing in pairs until I get back. That’s an order.” All of the cadets groaned again, but in silence, for fear of further retribution.

Octavia looked around at the group’s dejected expressions and barked, “Am I understood?” In regimented unison, each cadet barked back, “Yes, Force Captain!”

With a confident nod, Octavia finished by ordering the squad to “get to it.” She then snatched up her knapsack and stomped off down the path they’d followed earlier in the day.

For a minute or two, the entire squad was quiet around their crackling fire. Even Adora, who was usually quick to act on an officer’s orders, remained seated while she finished the last few bites of her dinner.

Once she was confident that their leader was full out of range, Catra was the first to voice her full distain. “I hope they catch her on her blind side. Then I’ll know I made the right choice when I clawed her eye out.”

This sudden, almost aggressive jeer elicited a laugh from the whole group. None of them were above ridiculing their Force Captain, so long as the woman herself couldn’t hear them.

Rogelio joined in next with a hearty series of roars, each punctuated with a softer arrangement of growls. This was

followed by yet more laughter, despite no one (save for Kyle) actually knowing what the lizard-boy said.

They all went back and forth like this for a few minutes while they cleaned out their mess kits. In time, though, Adora was the first to grab her collapsible quarterstaff and begin taking a few practice swings. The others took this as their que to get to work, given that Adora was their de-facto leader when the Force Captain was away.

Leader or not, Catra never held back from letting her friend hear her opinion on rudimentary training exercises. "I take back what I said earlier. I would gladly work forge duty for a week if it meant not having to run these same exercises again."

The displeasure wasn't rooted in boredom at all; instead, it revealed how confident Catra had become in her own combat capabilities. Even Adora had a hard time keeping pace when Catra was at her most dexterous. That didn't stop either of them from putting their best foot forward in practice combat, though. In fact, both played off each other for encouragement when it came time to sharpen their skills.

"They aren't that bad," Adora pointed out while taking a few swift jabs at the air. "But I get what you're saying. I'd like to be able to practice something else besides this and laser rifle marksmanship every now and then."

Catra retrieved her own quarterstaff and extended it with a sharp whipping motion. "Oh yeah, like what?"

"I don't know…maybe sword training? That'd be interesting," Adora shrugged.

Catra immediately began to laugh at the idea, doubling over as the thought of Adora with a sword crossed her mind. Once she was able to regain her composure, she simply shook her head and said, "You with a sword…now that's a sight I'd pay to see."

"I could fight with a sword…I think," Adora tried to assert before faltering. "I mean, how hard can it be?"

After assuming a battle stance at last, Catra simply looked at her training opponent and goaded, "I'm pretty sure you said the same thing in the first day of staff training. And now look at you…"

Adora knew exactly what Catra was doing – this was how she knocked any of her opponents off balance before any blows were exchanged. But she fell for it all the same by making the first strike without warning. Catra was ready for it, though, and managed to parley it with ease.

From there, Catra was ready to counterattack. She swung in Adora's direction and managed to land a quick hit on her shoulder. But Adora didn't react to the hit, choosing instead to use her staff put some distance between herself and the brunette. From there, she thought, she could reevaluate her opponent's strategy.

"Come on, Adora," Catra enticed with her usual bravado, "You don't usually let me land the first hit that easily."

"Maybe I let you have that one," Adora countered while moving into a crouching position. Then, without missing a beat, she lunged and used her staff to nail Catra square in the chest. The force of the hit was more than Catra was expecting and she staggered back slightly. But even her cat-like reactions weren't deadened by the hit and she managed to deftly grab Adora's staff in one hand.

With a yank, she then used the staff to pull her opponent within arm's reach. With her free hand, she lightly tapped the blonde's forehead, as if to prove her dominance in the fight. "You're still fighting like you're distracted, Adora."

She wouldn't admit it to herself, but that light, yet fierce gesture had distracted her right in that moment. But even before that, Adora knew that her mind had remained trained on what she saw in the cave earlier that day. Something about that pink sparkle of

light had called out to her more inquisitive instincts, making her want to investigate it now that night had fallen.

With a smooth motion, Adora swept backwards and extended her weapon to keep her combatant at range. “I’m not distracted. It’s just…I saw something earlier, when we were looking at that cave.”

With her staff now lowered to her side, Catra looked on and inquired, “Oh yeah? Like what?”

“There was something else in the cave…like, deep inside. I only saw it for a second, but it looked bright pink. It could have been another crystal, but…it was still dazzling.”

“Wow, I wish I’d seen that.” Catra’s tone sounded more sarcastic then she had intended.

Then, inspiration struck like lightning. Adora turned suddenly and looked off in the direction of the cave. It wasn’t in sight from there, but she figured they could just retrace their steps and find it pretty easily…

“That gives me an idea…”

Catra raised an eyebrow in interest. “What about? Because if it’s a plan to beat me, you might want to spend more than a second dreaming it up.”

Turning back toward Catra, Adora simply nodded and said, “follow my lead.” With that, she lunged forward, which implored Catra to retaliate. From there, Adora started to levy a series of strikes that required her to keep stepping backwards toward the tree line. Catra swung into each stance, which caused the pair to move outward from the campsite like ballroom dancers.

Eventually, Adora ducked one of Catra’s swings and intentionally fell backwards into the tree line with a *thud*. Catra stood by for a moment, expecting her friend to stand back up and continue the skirmish. But soon, a hand rose out of the bush and waved for

Catra to follow. She did so, but not before looking back to see the other cadets sparing back and forth.

Once she gracefully maneuvered through a thick shrub brush, Catra found Adora laying prone on the ground behind a mass of knurled roots.

"Umm…what are you doing," she questioned.

Like a groundhog, Adora popped her head up and quickly surveyed the scene. Her body language was that of someone trying to escape a predator's gaze. "Did anyone see us?"

Catra's confusion only continued to grow. "I don't think so. Why does it matter?"

With a few more sentry-like glances around the area, Adora rose from her hiding spot and walked over to where Catra now stood. "I just don't want to get caught, that's all."

"Get caught doing what, exactly?"

"Well…I thought that since Octavia was gone, we could…maybe sneak back up to that cave and check it out."

Catra gave her best friend a fully incredulous look. "So, you're saying you *don't* want to follow an officer's orders?"

"When you put it like that," Adora equivocated, "it sounds worse than it is…"

"I don't care one way or another. I just never thought I'd live to see the day that future-Force-Captain Adora intentionally breaks the rules."

"Hey! I can be fun sometimes."

"I never said you weren't," Catra replied while beginning to walk deeper into the woods. As she passed, she lightly tapped her friend's forehead again, as she had done while they spared.

"Anyway, I'm in. Let's go check out this mysterious pink light of yours."

Adora watched the brunette walk on for a moment or two, with just the night moons' light illuminating patches of the ground around her. The view brought a smile to her face that caused her to stare for just a moment too long.

"You coming?"

Catra had stopped and turned around while extending a hand. There was just enough light to see the gesture, but not enough for Catra to make out her friend's warm smile.

"Oh, um…yeah, sorry!"

Adora quickly sprinted to catch up as Catra began to trudge through the underbrush once more. She let the smile drop along the way, but still allowed its warmth to smolder internally.

Catra was quick to ask, "So, which way are we going again?"

Before responding, Adora glanced around the canopy above. The difference between night and day was stark, enough so that she wasn't sure which direction they had traveled during their initial sweep. So, she estimated to the best of her ability and pointed due south. "Let's try that way first."

And so, Catra and Adora began their pathfinding mission through the mountainous woods. Along the way, they managed to spot a couple landmarks – an unusual hill here, an exceptionally large tree there – and knew that they were on the right track. Pretty soon, they managed to pick up their old trail and followed it due north of the encampment site. That was when Catra used her more acute night vision to spot their destination.

"Look! I think that's it up ahead."

As she directed Adora's attention, she pointed up a short embankment. There, indeed, was the soft orange glow that the

pair had spotted at a distance during the daytime. But unlike before, this glow had become visible enough to illuminate the entire nearby clearing. This made it easier for the pair to pinpoint the cave's entrance, even from a considerable distance.

Upon approaching the cave, they again found no signs of inhabitants nearby. Adora even made sure to double check the ground around the entrance for tracks. With the coast cleared, the two young women paused at the cave's entryway to consider their options.

"Should we just go in, then?" Adora suggested, pointing toward the radiant interior. Her hesitance was showing through again, but she wasn't letting it hold her back this time.

Catra gave a small nod and peered inward. "Yeah. But let's take it slow. This place is giving me a weird feeling, too." After trying to spot the light Adora had described, Catra added, " You should lead, if we're looking for that pink thing you saw."

Adora agreed and started her way into the cave. Catra followed close behind, her eyes rapidly darting back and forth to check for obstacles. She could feel herself becoming more alert within the first few steps, despite few solid indications of impending danger.

Beyond the entrance, the cave's softly glowing orange crystal veins were occasionally interrupted by vine-like vegetation bursting from the stone walls. These vines cascaded down the walls and collected across the path, leading Adora to assume that few creatures had sought shelter in the burrow recently. Still, their path was fairly clear for the first several meters.

But by the time the cave's entrance was out of view, both Catra and Adora noticed the road ahead growing rougher and steeper. Darkness was not a problem for Catra, whose feline night vision kicked in immediately. Adora was able to adequately see within this confined space, too, thanks to the glowing crystal veins that flanked the passageway.

Up until that point, both Catra and Adora had remained silent, with their thoughts focused on their new surroundings. But soon enough, Catra asked, "Where is this thing you saw? If you saw it from the entrance, it can't be too far back here."

"I'd think so," Adora agreed, "but maybe I just saw a reflection of something further in."

Just as she said that, her eyes caught a flash of pink again. It was like a signal mirror being turned suddenly in her direction before winking away again. Adora looked around with some urgency, trying to see where the light had originated from – but to no avail.

Catra noticed the sudden reaction and looked on with some confusion. "What is it? Did you see something?"

Now crouching down to the floor and squinting up the pathway ahead, Adora replied, "I saw the light again. It was up ahead but…it's gone now."

"Then let's keep going. Maybe it's…moving or something," Catra suggested. But the thought of something both moving and glowing didn't sound all that enticing. After all, "moving" and "glowing" were traits of the Whispering Woods' inhabitants and she wasn't about to run into that engagement unprepared.

Adora rose and nodded before starting down the path again. She was walking slower and more cautiously now, which gave Catra more time to really take in the sights around her. *Adora was right,* she thought, *this place really is something else.* In particular, her heterochromatic eyes took in the warm light of their surroundings. It was so unlike the cold, impersonal lights of the Fright Zone – instead, it was gentle and mediated, like a new day's light. And every iota of this orange light fell softly on Adora, whose back she could have stared at all day.

As quick as the soft thought popped into her mind, Catra shook it away. She didn't have time for that right now. They were on a mission, after all…sort of. It was more of an expedition, she

supposed, one that they had undertaken of their own accord. It had been Adora's idea, though, despite her usual insistence against such detours. There was something rebellious in this adventure that Catra couldn't help but admire in her friend, even if she didn't want to get lost in the thought right then and there.

Fortunately for her, she didn't have to focus on those thoughts for another moment. Just as the pair found their way over a large boulder in their path, they both saw the bright pink light at the same time. It winked out of view again in almost the same instant, but it was enough to catch both young women's attention.

"You saw it this time, right?" Adora inquired as they looked up ahead to the flash's source.

Catra nodded, "Yeah, and it looked close by." Her estimation was confirmed immediately after when another pink glimmer appeared and evaporated before their eyes. This was followed by a third and fourth flash which lingered for longer than the first pair. They eventually faded as well, but their appearance made it clear that their source was no more than a few meters away.

"It must be right up ahead," Adora suggested, her anticipation becoming apparent in her tone. "In fact…"

She trailed off as the light made another encore appearance. But this time, the light didn't fade away or flicker at all. It shone without flinching, making its source easy to see through a pile of rubble up ahead.

Without saying anything else, Adora ran ahead and into what appeared to be the cave's terminus. There, moonlight poured in from above through what appeared to be a hole in the cave's ceiling. Though it was high above them, Adora could make out some trees hanging over the opening's exterior, implying that the rocky pileup before them was the result of a cave-in. That cave-in must have occurred some time ago as well, given the sheer volume of rocky debris that littered the chamber's floor.

By now, Catra had caught up and was taking in the scene as well. Her eyes adjusted to the moonlit cavern as she turned from looking up at the ceiling's opening to the sparkling pink light near the far wall. Adora had turned her attention there as well, leading her to step forward cautiously and inspect the source.

After a moment, she called back, "I think it's some kind of… crystal. It doesn't look very big, though."

Catra stepped up to the rock pile and crouched down for her own inspection. "Pretty small, yeah. I can't believe it was putting off that much light. I wonder how it got here?"

"I'm not sure…but I bet I could get it out." With that, Adora unceremoniously began to pull a few fist-sized boulders out of the pile and toss them aside. Catra reached out and grasped a boulder as well, but then dropped it suddenly when she heard the sound of rock shifting and tumbling from above.

In a lightning-fast motion, she swung out her arm and pulled Adora back. The next instant, the pair was splayed out backwards on the rocky cave floor with a cloud of dust rising up from their point of impact. Without any hesitation, Catra jumped back up to her feet and braced herself for an impending rockslide.

But as a few more seconds went by, it became apparent that the rock pile before them was not about to tumble. Instead, an assortment of small rocks and pebbles trickled down harmlessly near the spot where Adora had grabbed the first stone. Adora herself looked a bit shaken up at the suddenness of the whole event.

"Hey, what was that for?"

Catra's heart was still racing and her hair still stool on end. She had only just recognized that the danger had passed – if it had even been there in the first place.

"I thought…I thought the pile was collapsing. I didn't want you to get trapped."

After rising and brushing herself off, Adora reexamined the heap before them. "I think it's alright. I'll just take it slower." She knelt down again, just beside where she had started her dig, and added, "but thank you. I'm glad that you were watching by back."

"You'd have done the same for me."

Catra meant it, too – she knew that, no matter what kind of trouble they managed to get into, Adora would always have her back. They'd been through everything together, after all, from childhood onward. They'd both antagonized Shadow Weaver in tandem, and they'd managed to make it through basic training by playing to each other's strengths. This spelunking trip would be another grand adventure in that tradition and would surely give them something that they could brag about to the other cadets when they got back to the Fright Zone.

But those rosy recollections would have to wait after Catra again registered the sound of rocks slipping against one another. Her eyes immediately darted to Adora, and then up at the rock pile above and in front of her. It looked as if she was making steady progress on her dig, with the walnut-sized crystal now coming into full view. But after checking the entire pile for movement, Catra saw nothing of interest.

The sound of rocks moving rung out again, this time from near the room's entrance. Catra walked over swiftly and checked out the area for threats, only to receive a sudden blow to the back. The hit knocked her off balance, but not enough to prevent her from twisting around and assuming a battle stance, claws out.

But much to the brunette's surprise, there was nothing and no one behind her – save for Adora, who was still digging at the trapped pink gem within the rock pile. Catra worried for a moment that she was becoming paranoid about the cave's dangers, despite being the one who wanted to check out this cave in the first place. But then, out of what felt like thin air, her lingering apprehensions were confirmed in the form of an airborne stone headed in her direction.

Catra managed to nimbly dodge the mass and roll back toward the center of the room. This sudden movement caused Adora to turn around and see her friend crouched down low, as if ready to strike back at an unseen enemy. Just as she readied herself to dodge away again, Catra noticed that Adora held a sizable rock at that very moment, in a manner that indicated her readiness to toss it over her back.

"What was that for?" Catra's tone sounded unintentionally harsh, but she was still on edge from the last several minutes of action.

Adora simply looked at the stone in her hand and replied, "Oh, this?"

"Yeah, why did you throw a rock at me?"

Adora looked at the rock again and then heaved it into the corner near the entryway. The rock landed with a *thud* and then seemed to disappear into the floor. Further sounds of rocks sliding rung out as the stone came to rest out of view.

"Did I? I'm sorry! Are you okay?"

The blonde started to rise and walk over towards her friend. But Catra waived her off.

"I'm fine, really."

"Are you sure?"

"Yeah. It just surprised me, that's all."

Over the years, Adora had learned that Catra would hide her injuries, regardless of their severity. She knew her friend was guarding right then as well, but she thought better of pressing the issue.

"As long as you're sure." Adora then turned back to the pile and pointed with her thumb, "I think if I move that last big one right there, I'll be able to get the crystal. Can you help me?"

To show her physical willingness, Catra placed her hands on her lower back and leaned back slightly. Her back then popped audibly, as did her neck after she twisted it slightly from side-to-side. A satisfied grin appeared on her face, indicating that the thrown stone had left her no worse for wear.

"Yeah, let's do it."

The pair then walked over and stooped beside the boulder in question. Catra was actually surprised at it size up close, which matched the largest of the Horde gym's kettle bells. Upon grasping the hunk of earth, both young soldiers also realized that this stone was comparably heavy to those kettle bells.

After one false start, Adora decided to count them in.

"Ready! One…two…three!"

And with the third count, the pair cleanly hoisted the boulder from the base of the pile. It became clear immediately that even together, the pair couldn't hold the mass for long. So, Adora motioned with her head over toward the room's entryway, where she had already thrown the other rocks. They then carefully stepped in that direction, making sure to not slip on any of the compact stones that made up the chamber's walkable surface.

Once they were close enough, Adora signaled again, this time to concertedly toss the stone aside.

"Ready again! One…two…three!"

Their timing was perfect, allowing them to cleanly toss the hefty slab aside. It sailed briefly through the air before landing squarely with a heavy, hollow *thud* that reverberated all through the cavern. But much to the pair's mutual surprise, the stone's motion didn't cease there.

Instead, the boulder appeared to sink through a layer of pebbles upon impact. A couple seconds later, it had entirely disappeared

from view, leaving only a gaping hole in what had previously looked like solid ground.

Catra and Adora only had enough time to exchange a glance of confusion before they felt the ground begin to shift beneath them. At first, the motion felt like an earthquake. But soon enough, Adora realized that the rocks beneath her boots had begun to shift, causing her to sink slightly. Without further hesitation, she darted back toward the main rock pile, in hopes of grabbing the now-accessible pink crystal.

At the same moment, Catra found herself still on solid ground. As she watched Adora bolt to the far end of the room, she began to see the rock piles near the chamber's entrance cave in entirely. This, she realized, was causing the chamber floor to collapse as well, at a pace that couldn't be slowed down. Her fight-or-flight senses kicked in in response, causing her to reach out to pull Adora towards herself.

But her rescue attempt was already too late. Instead of grasping onto the blonde's sturdy wrist, Catra only came up with a fistful of air. Adora, to her credit, had already sped across the compact chamber and knelt down beside the main rock heap. By the time Catra realized that her friend was out of reach, Adora had turned back to her with the glowing sphere in hand.

"Catra! Look! I got it!"

That was all she had time to say.

Pink

As Adora's voice echoed out through the chamber, the cave-in reached a fever pitch. Now, the larger piles near the center of the room had begun to crumble, casting huge boulders to and fro. Though Adora couldn't see them, slabs as large as her torso had begun to thunder down, with one particularly jagged piece landing just behind her back.

Catra, though, could see it all happen in real time. Panic raced through her core, which filled her with the energy needed to make the risky dash into harm's way. But her limbs refused to listen, freezing her in place. Though she wanted to grab Adora and run as far from the collapsing chamber as possible, she could only muster a shout at this critical moment.

"Adora! This whole place is falling apart! We need to go – now!"

As another massive stone impacted beside her, Adora became fully aware of the dire situation. After springing to her feet, she yelled back, "Okay! I'm coming!"

But as she extended her foot to dash back to Catra's side, she realized that her right foot had begun to sink into the rapidly deteriorating floor. The myriad pebbles' weight was too great for her to escape, causing her to trip and fall flat. Adora then tried to spring back up but found the shifting gravel wouldn't hold her weight at all. This caused her to sink even further, to the point that she was being dragged down and toward a newly-formed fissure.

"Catra! I'm stuck. I…I can't get up!"

Adora's cry for help rung out in Catra's ears louder than any of the nearby thundering stones. Again, she tried to will her legs into motion, but they were as good as frozen to the dirt floor. A full paralysis had set in as she realized that she couldn't reach Adora, even if she did manage to dodge the falling boulders and dig her

free. Her friend was sinking fast, falling into who knows where – the center of the planet, for all she knew.

"No no no…Adora! Don't give up!" Her cry was accented by real tears, which had begun to fill her eyes and obscure her view. "Please! You have to keep trying!"

Then, all at once, Catra felt her legs reactivate, allowing her to finally bound into the fray. But as she cast out her hand again in a final, desperate rescue attempt, she watched Adora slip deeper into the choppy torrent of rushing rubble.

"I've got you, Adora! Just keep your arm out!"

After leaping cleanly over a tombstone-sized boulder, Catra braced herself as she tried to grab Adora's outstretched arm.

"I can almost reach you!"

But Adora couldn't see her partner's effort due to the numerous small rocks that had begun to spring up in her face. She tried to shield herself with her free hand, but the cascade was too great. The force of the rock slide was carrying her down quicker and quicker - faster than Catra could handle without diving in herself.

That didn't stop her from trying. By now, Catra was fully laid out prone, trying to extend her reach to the last inch. It wasn't enough though, as Adora finally became submerged up to her shoulders in tiny pebbles. Despite the force upon her, Adora still tried to thrash free. Her desperate shout was the last thing Catra heard before she was pulled fully into the fissure.

"Please! Go get help!"

Catra hardly had time to register the request when another sizable slab landed directly in front of her. This cast her gaze upward, where a pair of rocky shards had just broken loose from the scrum. With a nimble lunge backwards, Catra avoided both in the nick of time. But the monoliths both blocked her path back toward the fissure, making it all but impossible to follow after Adora.

By now, Catra's fight-or-flight reactions had fully shifted into gear, causing her to dodge several more boulders that fell in her immediate vicinity. Her heart wanted her to run back to the fissure and hope against all hope that her friend was still there, holding on for dear life. But her head told her to run, to hide, to get away from this threat to her safety.

There was no time to debate, so her head won out. Despite her blurry vision, Catra sprinted back toward the chamber entrance, where the ground didn't appear to be crumbling. Once there, she turned back with a sense of horror. What she saw was the remainder of the chamber sliding away, like sand through an hourglass. Adora was nowhere to be seen, which caused a scream of fear to rise and trap itself in Catra's throat. It became wedged beside another call out to Adora, who she now believed had been entirely crushed beneath the rocky onslaught.

The scream was followed by more tears, even as the last of the chamber's stones sifted away into a dark expanse below. Catra fell to her knees and curled in toward herself, clinging to the newly-created cliff edge with all of her might. Again, she felt paralyzed and entirely unable to run for help. It was as if every stone around that tiny pink crystal had been chained to her limbs to keep her anchored to this spot forever.

To Catra, it felt like an eternity had passed while she remained rooted to that spot. So much boiling emotion had begun to bubble to the surface, in streams of tears and choked attempts for air. Again and again, she slammed her fist into the cave wall, once even hard enough to crack a crystal vein. Though she didn't see it, this fracture caused the vein to lose it luminosity. It wasn't enough to dim the passageway, though, which was still filled with a warm orange light that reflected off each new teardrop.

In time, Catra managed to get a good breath in and wipe a few tears out of her eyes. Upon opening her eyes once more, the abhorrent nature of her surroundings came rushing back. Before her lay a pit with no perceivable bottom. Everything that had once

been in that chamber – Adora included – had disappeared into a planetary void.

Catra couldn't find it in herself to look over the edge at first, fearful that the darkness below would find a way to reach up and drag her down. But with a few more solid breaths in, she managed to crawl forward and peer over. As she had suspected, the hole continued down and down until nothing more could be seen. Not even the moonlight pouring in from above could help Catra make heads or tails of its depth.

But one particular light beam shone down toward the former chamber's entryway, where Catra still rested on her knees. Its trajectory led it far short of the entryway, however, terminating instead on the wall below the cliff's edge. Catra's eyes instinctively followed the moonlight beam, expecting it to reveal the sheer angle of the sink hole's walls.

What she saw there instead made her blink once…twice…three times over. She thought perhaps her vision was still distorted from the salt in her eyes. Maybe it was even wishful thinking but somehow, she saw Adora laying at the base of the moonbeam. At first, it looked as if the blonde was hovering on the abyss' inky surface. But as Catra squinted for a closer look, she realized that Adora was splayed out on a flat, rocky outcropping of her approximate size.

Despite the pain she still felt in her throat, this sight caused a roar to rise from Catra's lungs.

"Adora! Adora, are you okay?"

She felt her voice crack a bit, but it didn't matter. Adora – or whatever this apparition was – didn't respond. If it was the young woman herself, she was out cold, likely from the force of the rockfall and her descent through it.

Upon staring for another minute at Adora's unresponsive form, Catra came to a realization – if her friend was knocked out, she

couldn’t stay on that outcropping for long. After all, it could give way just as suddenly as the room above it had. She needed to be rescued right now, before this miraculous second chance slipped away.

Real or not, Catra was going to try to get the person she cared for most in the world back from the precipice.

But how…

Scaling the sheer cliff face wasn’t an option. Catra knew that her claws were durable, but she didn’t want to risk slipping during the climb back up. Some rope would have allowed her to quickly repel down the sink hole’s wall, too. But she didn’t have that at her disposal, at least without running back to camp and tipping off the rest of the squad to Adora’s predicament.

After only a minute of contemplation, Catra knew that those options wouldn’t suffice. Improvisation seemed like the only clear path forward now…or at least, the most viable path downward.

It didn’t take long to find something suitable to stand in for a repelling cord. Catra immediately recalled the vines that she’d slashed through on the way in. They’d been plenty fibrous, at least enough for them to climb from floor to ceiling with apparent ease. Catra supposed they could hold her weight as well, with some modification.

Years later, Catra would never have admitted that a skill she’d learned in Horde training helped to save her best friend’s life. But as she finally rose from the cave passageway floor, she thought about braiding a few of the vines together to make a make-shift rope. Then, she could walk herself down the cliff face, snatch up Adora, and get her back to safety.

That was the plan, anyway, and she set about putting it into action. After walking back down the passage a few meters, she was able to cut free several long, undamaged tendrils. From there, she bound one set of ends together and began to spin the

whole arrangement manually. Quickly, it became apparent that this impromptu twine would be exceptionally bulky, like something that might be used to secure a ship in harbor. But as far as Catra was concerned, the thicker, the better.

After spooling each vine's entire length together and securing the opposite end with a knot, Catra began to heave the braided cord back to the cliff's edge. Once there, she peaked down to see if Adora (or at least, the figment of Adora that Catra's mind had dreamed up in the throes of her grief) was still there. Adora remained, and the sight brought Catra a sense of resolve that she hoped would power her into the unknown below.

With a sense of purpose now kindled within her, Catra tossed the secured vine rope down toward the ledge below. Its end landed over atop Adora, but she still didn't stir. The rope's end careened further as well, eventually falling over the outcropping's ledge. Upon seeing that, Catra knew that she had more than enough length to work with.

With one final peak at what lay below, Catra grasped the rope, kneeled down, and lowered herself over the edge. At first, she thought that she felt the natural cord breaking under her (admittedly light) weight. But it was only the slack drawing out of the line, allowing Catra to secure her footing. The climb would be several meters in lateral distance, so she committed herself to taking the whole thing slow and steady.

Those first few steps were shaky at best. The Horde might have prepared her to improvise a rope out of natural materials, but it had not taught her to repel down a sheer rock face. So, in effect, she was going to learn to repel correctly on the fly, over a pit of unknown depth. Also, the stakes were considerably high, given that Adora wouldn't likely be found if she couldn't be rescued from this pit.

Catra's heart was still racing, too, despite the time that had passed since the initial cave-in. Adrenaline still pulsed through her veins, as well, which may have been why she had been able to

buck up the courage to make this climb in the first place. It may not have helped her keep steady as she took each step toward downward, but it did keep her focused. Adora was counting on her, after all – assuming the young woman below wasn't just a figment of her imagination, that is.

Before she knew it, Catra had already completed half of her treacherous descent. She only had the moonlight from above to light her way, but she could still see her intended landing site. Space would be at a premium once she touched down on Adora's rocky outcropping, that was now clear. But she continued to climb down despite this added challenge. In her heart, she felt ready to overcome any obstacle necessary to get Adora to safety.

Step by step, Catra managed to lower herself the remaining distance and land flat-footed on the natural platform. After letting out a breath to relieve her pent up tension, she turned and knelt down beside Adora. A cursory glance revealed a sizable bruise on the unconscious woman's head, which stood out dark against her blonde hairline. Clearly, an impact or two had knocked her out, either before or after the gravel flow deposited her on the ledge.

There was nothing Catra could do for such an injury here, which she immediately recognized. The sooner she got her back to camp, the sooner the squad could triage each injury. A deep sigh revealed Catra's apprehension about completing the impending ascent, however. After all, she'd need to keep Adora secured for the entire climb.

But the challenge ahead didn't tarnish the brunette's resolve. *I've made it this far*, she thought to herself while fighting off further tears, *I'm not giving up now.*

Before trying to hoist up the young woman splayed out before her, Catra figured that she should check on her present condition. To start, she shook Adora's slightly. This didn't return any reaction, but it did cause Catra to notice the numerous scraps and scratches across Adora's usually unblemished face. A renewed

ache settled into Catra's gut upon seeing this and knowing that if she'd hadn't hesitated, she could have prevented all of this.

Another quick glance over Adora's exposed arms and legs revealed yet more stone-worn bruises. *If Adora made it through this*, Catra thought, *she'll be feeling it for a while.* Deep down, she didn't believe that there was any "if" to deal with in this situation. Catra was all but certain that Adora *would* be okay, once they were out of this pit. After all, she had to be okay…she *had* to be okay.

As she inspected Adora's bruises for severity, Catra noticed something else – chest movement. That small sign of life sent a spark through Catra's core. It didn't make her doubt the pain of Adora's other injuries. But it still gave her a reason to hope that despite the unbelievable odds thrown at them in the last hour, they'd walk out of this orange-lit cavern together.

"Adora? Can you hear me? Are you hurt?"

If she was breathing, Catra figured, perhaps she was conscious, too, at least enough to indicate her injuries. But Adora still didn't respond, besides taking in a slightly deeper breath. Catra repeated her inquiry, but it was again meet without response. Even a third attempt didn't yield any success, leading Catra to assume that her friend was out cold, at least for now.

With that, Catra resigned herself to the task ahead. It wouldn't be easy, given that she'd need to carry Adora's full weight all the way back up on a rope made only from cave vines. To say that she wasn't feeling confident would have been an understatement. But an adversarial relationship with the odds was nothing new for Catra. She knew what it took to overcome unyielding obstacles like this, and that secret impetus was already glowing warmly in her heart.

Before hoisting Adora up, Catra kneeled down and leaned in over Adora's face. She was close enough to whisper, but she spoke clearly, hoping that her instructions might break through the fog.

"I'm going to try to carry you up. If you can hear me, don't move too much. I don't know if this rope can hold us both but…I'm going to try."

Still no response. Catra let out a worry-laden sigh, recognizing that there was no reason to delay further. But before readying herself for the lift, she leaned down further and lightly pecked Adora's forehead with a kiss. As soon as she pulled back, her mind questioned why she had done it. But her heart knew well enough, even if Adora wouldn't know for now.

With those gentle thoughts still floating in the back of her mind, Catra knelt down fully and hoisted Adora up. The blonde's weight didn't surprise her – they had spared many times previously, after all. But in all of those simulated engagements, Adora had never been throwing her full weight on Catra's back. Now, limp as she was, Catra had to shoulder her friend's full weight while questioning how someone so muscular could also be so dense.

As best she could, Catra tried to get Adora's unconscious form into a comfortable position over her own shoulder. The added weight would make the climb more tedious, but Catra was as ready as she was ever going to be to make the attempt. Finally, with one arm securing her friend and the other grasping the vine, Catra started her walk back up the sheer wall without even momentarily looking back into the darkness below.

Immediately, Catra began to feel the strain of her added burden. The extra weight was something to contend with, sure, but Catra also felt her elbows and knees locking up with tension. After only a few feet of climbing, Catra realized that she'd be putting a lot of effort into maintaining Adora's balance while she switched hands on the vine. All of this made Catra momentarily doubt if she could safely get them back to the chamber's entryway above.

Once she found her pace, though, Catra's confidence grew bit by bit. By the halfway point, her muscles started to ache less, and she became fully certain that the vine rope would hold out. Of

course, the adrenaline pumping into her veins helped as well, now that she had no choice but to continue her ascent.

Looking up, Catra again saw the soft orange glow of the passageway pouring into the former chamber's darkness. She was close enough now that she could pick up the pace and carry them both over the top. But just as she readied herself for the final push, as soft voice registered in her ear.

"Catra…what's going on?"

An involuntary gasp escaped Catra's lips. *She's awake…she's alive!*

Catra dug in her feet while trying to shift Adora's weight slightly. Through her labored panting, she did her best to softly reply.

"Adora…the whole room collapsed, and it pulled you in. But we're almost out."

After drawing in another heavy breath, she added an order worthy of a Force Captain - "Don't move."

Though Adora didn't reply to the command, Catra could feel her breathing more deeply now. Thankfully, they were now just an arm's length or two from the top. So, with a final burst of strength, Catra hoisted them both up and over the threshold. The burst had been just enough because, after propping Adora up against a nearby boulder, Catra collapsed, her oxygen-starved lungs and muscles finally catching up to her.

For several minutes, the pair remained like this, with Adora slowly returning to consciousness and Catra gasping for a full breath. The cave's naturally cool air helped them both recover progressively, enough to speak clearly.

Adora's voice rose up first, but only at a murmur. "We made it. I can't believe it."

Her breathing now regulated again, Catra couldn't help but pull out an exhausted smirk. "Don't act so surprised."

“I thought…I thought that was it. You…you saved me.”

She didn’t feel like a hero right there and then, but Catra still felt a small spark of pride flicker in her core. “Like I said before, you’d have done the same for me.”

That justification hung in the air between the pair while they continued to recuperate. By now, they both knew with certainty that their absence from the encampment would have been noticed by the rest of the squad, if not also by Octavia. Even if their little escapade had gone unnoticed, Kyle, Rogelio, and Lonnie would surely have questions when they saw their mutual condition.

But for now, neither of them thought about any impending reprimands or inquiries. Instead, they simply focused on breathing, on gathering energy for the walk back, and on each other.

When they first entered the glowing cave, Adora figured that she’d be the one leading the way out. But now, with her ankle twisted and beginning to swell, she leaned heavily on Catra for support. Together, they managed to clamber down the passageway and back to the cave’s entrance. There, they were greeted by the darkness of midnight, as well as the same brilliant moonlight that had illuminated the former crystal chamber.

Even through the effort needed to support Adora’s limp, Catra began to feel her heartbeat slow to a normal pace as they passed back into the moonlit clearing. Only then did she realize the non-stop rush of the previous several hours, starting from the moment they’d committed to exploring the cave. Now that the coast had cleared, Catra could tell that she’d been on high alert the whole time, even before the rocks started to fall. It had zapped most of

her energy certainly, but she knew that every vigilant second had paid off in the long run.

At the same time, though, Catra's steadied heartbeat reminded her of the dread that had also coursed through her when the chamber started collapsing. Up until she saw Adora's still form on the ledge, Catra really had believed that her friend was gone forever. Not only that, but an unimaginable rage had poured through her because she immediately believed that Adora's fate had been her fault.

Even now, reflections on those fresh thoughts brought warm tears back to Catra's eyes. But she managed to wipe them away before Adora noticed.

Through all of that conscious pain, Catra realized that she'd never for a moment considered the concept of Adora being gone for good. She had no point of reference at all, being as she had hardly any clear memories from a time before Adora was by her side. They'd grown up and grown close together, so Catra had never paid a moment's thought to the idea of a world without that truth.

So, when the idea flashed into her mind as she watched Adora slip below the rocky tide, it had truly overwhelmed her. It had blinded her to a certain degree, enough that she was ready to risk herself on the improbable chance that Adora had survived the crush.

"Hey, can we stop for a moment? My other ankle needs a break."

Adora's request for rest had broken Catra out of her silent contemplation. She nodded and helped the blonde find a spot to sit against a downed log. Once there, Catra sat down against the log as well and let out a sigh.

"We should be close to camp now. Can you make it the rest of the way or do you want me to carry you again?"

Adora let out a contained laugh and shook her head. "I can make it. Besides, you've carried me enough today."

Catra didn't need to be told. She could still feel the strain in her neck and back. She didn't say as much, though. Even without it being said, she was certain that Adora's current downtrodden expression betrayed some guilt for the evening's perils.

After a few moments of silence between them, Adora spoke up again. "I know it won't mean much but… I'm sorry. I didn't mean to put us in harm's way like that." While shuffling though her pockets, she added, "I don't even know if it was worth it."

Then, much to Catra's surprise, Adora withdrew the small, rose-colored crystal orb from her pocket. Adora's fall hadn't deadened its radiance at all. Even without direct moonlight shining upon it, the orb still glowed lightly, enough to softly illuminate the space between them.

With her arm extended, Adora offered the stone in Catra's direction. "Here, take it. I managed to slip it into my pocket before I got stuck. I was worried that it fell out when I landed but…there it is."

Even with the stone's light reflecting in her eyes, Catra shook her head. "I can't take that. You literally risked your life for it."

"I was going to give it to you anyway. So, take it."

"Oh" was all Catra could muster. She tried to act humble in response, but she could only draw up a few stutters. "I…but…it's yours."

"Seriously. I want you to have it. I'd say you've earned it now."

While looking down at the crystal's rosy hue, Catra finally relented and placed out her hand.

"Thank you."

Once they started their walk back to camp again, Catra clutched the orb tight in her hand. It was still warm from where Adora had grasped it and protected it during her fall. Though it could have

easily reminded her of their mutually-harrowing experience, Catra was surprised to find that the orb kept her anchored in the moment. Though it was inert, this smooth hunk of crystal magically managed to keep Catra focused on the person safely beside her, rather than flashing back to the moment that she'd nearly lost her.

Much to Catra's surprise, Adora fell asleep almost as soon as they made it back to their tent. By some miracle, none of the other cadets had noticed their absence. As best as Catra could tell, Octavia wasn't even back, meaning that they were effectively in the clear. They'd have to find some way to explain Adora's injuries in the morning, but that was a task for their future selves.

For as weary as she felt, Catra had a hard time drifting off. Her head rested on her pillow, directly across from a now-snoring Adora. The tranquility in her eyes was truly remarkable, given all that she'd been through that night. It was a tranquility she could have stared at for hours on end, even if it meant forgoing sleep entirely.

The pink crystal orb rested on the tent floor, unmoving but still luminous. It glowed pink in the night between them, illuminating each of their faces while still hiding Catra's blush. Occasionally, she'd lightly touch the stone again to feel its residual heat – a reminder of energy that had guided her over the edge only a few hours prior. She wasn't sure how Adora had imbued it with so much warmth from holding it in her palm alone.

But Catra didn't really care how she did it, in the long run. She didn't care about sleeping or about what they'd tell their commanding officer the next morning. Now, all she cared about

was making that orb's light and warmth last. At this point, she'd do just about anything to feel it again and again and again.

The Fright Zone's senior barracks were quiet without any of its usual residents. Many of the older cadets were out on field assignments, gathering intel on Bright Moon's latest weakness. Others were stationed in the Horde's several captured kingdoms, from Dryl to Salineas. Regardless of their duties, there was hardly time for rest these days, what with Catra in charge.

The Force Captain herself typically didn't make an appearance in the barracks until the small hours of the morning. But on this night, her rage was far too great for her to contain out in public. She could feel herself losing control again, just like she did the day Scorpia left. Fire roared in her vein, causing her to lash out at every unfortunate cadet that stood between her and the privacy of her sleeping quarters.

Once there, her patience for even the door's keypad ran thin. With a furious slash, her claws dragged through the glass and wiring, causing the lock mechanism to de-activate. The door slide open, revealing the vacant dormitory with its several rows of aligned bunks. Its uniformity caused another bubble of lava-like rage to pop in Catra's mind. She was mere inches from dragging down several bunks with her hands alone when she realized that the door had remained open.

After slamming it shut, Catra's right fist slammed against the same door, causing a small dent to form in its scratched and rusted surface. The pain of the impact didn't even register in Catra's mind, nor did the feeling of crushing the adjacent communicator screen. Her body felt ready for the war path, but it also felt ready to sleep for the rest of eternity.

For weeks now, the Force Captain had been going without regular sleep. Every now and then, she'd find a few moments of rest in the same broom closets she used to hide in to escape Shadow Weaver's wrath. Now, they were one of her only refuges from the rigors of leadership, many of which she thought she was prepared to shoulder.

But now that the Horde had an opportunity to strike a true blow against the Rebellion, she felt compelled to remain in constant motion. The result was a mind clouded with uncertainty and anxiety, not to mention dark bags beneath her heterochromatic eyes. No one was safe from her lit-fuse temper, either – not even her former squad mates, Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle.

This fit of outward fury was like so many others before it. But rather than being triggered by the day's stresses, Catra's thoughts had gotten the best of her this time around. At first, her fears of failure had started to drag her down and paralyze her, as they often had throughout her young life. But then, her conscious tried to fight the poisonous feeling by lashing out at her own perceived weakness. The result was another communicator pad thrown hard across the room, and a set of claw marks across the war room wall.

Storming out of the war room was no cure, either. Neither was shouting at her poor subordinates when they dared to ask, "what's wrong?" Even if she had given them a half-respectful answer, she wasn't entirely sure it would have been honest. For as often as these outbursts occurred, Catra had never been able to pinpoint a trigger. It was always one thing or another that was out of control, and before long, her own emotions had followed the same course.

More than anything else, though, Catra felt imperially alone in this enormous cathedral of tech and steel. For almost three years now, she'd been without anyone to talk to about…anything real. When something changed in the Horde, it used to be Adora's ear she'd talk off. Day in and day out, the pair often used to pass on sleep

in favor more time together, laughing and joking without a care in the world.

Now, though, Catra had no one. She'd tried to catch Scorpia's ear, but that was a failing effort. Double Trouble had let her release her anger upon them more than once, but that was only because she paid them for their efforts. There was no one left in the Horde that actually cared to listen to her without judgement. Now, everyone was just afraid when she bore her fangs.

All of this loneliness fermented into anger over time, an anger that was ready to boil over at any sign of tension. At this very moment, her cup ran over with that poison, which threatened to tear the ambitious woman down at her moment of ascendancy. Worse yet, she had come to realize that the victory she wanted most wasn't going to fill the void eating away at her insides. It felt as if only Adora could do that now, with that same unknowable magic she'd unconsciously used throughout their childhood…but in the white flames of the moment, that seemingly simple solution felt an entire galaxy away.

Instead, Catra allowed her spite to surge outward, like the unyielding flow of rocks that had threatened to swallow up the woman she loved so many years ago. Where her frantic energy had once managed to recover her first and only friend from the fissure's edge, it now chaotically wrecked row after row of bunks. Each fell to the steel floor with a clatter that only encouraged the restless brunette to continue her rampage further.

Finally, when there was nothing more to upturn in view, Catra tore her headpiece free and chucked it across the room. It impacted the far wall with a clatter and ricocheted. By the time it landed on the ground, Catra had fallen to her knees, red hot tears forming and falling from her eyes. Her heart ached without any end in sight, wanting just one sign in the world that she could be happy again.

All the while, in a small wooden box tucked inside a nearby air duct, a walnut-sized, orb-shaped piece of crystal rested beside old

photos and trinkets. Its rose-colored light still shone as bright as it had in a cave years ago, when it became the object of Adora's gaze. Some residual warmth still clung to its surface, too, even though the person who cherished it most had gone so long without taking it in hand.

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